SAFE

Washing your hands removes germs that can make you sick. Cleaning the counter helps stop germs from spreading to your food. This way, your sandwich stays safe to eat.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

NOT SAFE

Mold can grow roots deep inside the jam, not just on the fuzzy part you see. These molds might make you sick, so it's best to throw the jam away if you see mold.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

IT DEPENDS

Potato salad should not be left out too long because warm temperatures make bacteria grow fast. If it was out for more than 2 hours or your home is very warm, it's safer to throw it away. If it was less time and feels cool, it might still be safe.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

SAFE

Washing your hands well and cleaning surfaces with soap helps remove harmful germs. This stops bacteria or viruses from getting into your food. This is one of the best ways to keep food safe and prevent food poisoning.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

NOT SAFE

Leaving meat like hot dogs in warm weather for more than 2 hours lets bacteria grow fast. This food is in the "danger zone" temperature where germs can make you sick. Eating it can cause food poisoning.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

IT DEPENDS

Pickles are acidic foods, which usually stop dangerous bacteria from growing. However, if the pickles were not made with enough vinegar or the jar was contaminated, they might not be safe. Keep pickles refrigerated after opening to be safe.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

SAFE

Keeping perishable foods like cooked chicken and potato salad cold (below 40°F) and out of the danger zone (40-140°F) slows harmful bacteria growth. Serving within two hours ensures safety. The cooler being in the shade with ice packs maintained the needed cold temperature.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

NOT SAFE

Cooked meat left at room temperature for more than two hours is unsafe because harmful bacteria grow quickly in the 'danger zone' between 40°F and 140°F. Eating this hamburger could cause food poisoning, as bacteria like Salmonella multiply rapidly.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

IT DEPENDS

Blanching then freezing vegetables slows bacterial growth, making freezing safe. But if vegetables thaw and warm above 40°F for too long, bacteria can grow and make them unsafe. If they still have ice crystals when power returns and were kept cold enough less than two days, refreezing can be safe.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

SAFE

Keeping perishable cooked foods like chicken chilled below 40°F and consuming them within 2 hours prevents harmful bacterial growth. This practice fits the 2-hour rule recommended for food safety in warm conditions, especially important for protein-rich foods. Proper cooling and timely consumption are key to preventing foodborne illness.

Source: SP 50-814 Summer food safety

NOT SAFE

A bulging lid and off odors in home-canned low-acid foods signal possible bacterial growth including dangerous botulism toxin. Such cans must never be opened or consumed. These are clear signs of spoilage and pose a serious health risk.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism

IT DEPENDS

Safety hinges on the acidity level and processing adjustments for altitude. Tomatoes are borderline in acidity; without added acid like lemon juice or citric acid, the salsa may be unsafe in a boiling water bath. Also, altitude requires longer processing time or higher pressure to destroy pathogens. Without proper acidification and altitude adjustment, canned salsa may be unsafe.

Source: SP 50-1001 PH values

SAFE

This is safe because the peaches were fresh, clean, and packed in jars with new lids. The jars were boiled in a water bath canner, which cooks the fruit enough to keep germs away and seal the jars properly.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

NOT SAFE

Even if the jar lid is sealed, mold means tiny germs grew inside and the jam is spoiled. Eating moldy jam can make you sick, so it's not safe. Always throw away jams with mold.

Source: Troubleshooting canning acid foods

IT DEPENDS

Leaving fruit out before canning can let germs grow. If the jam smells bad or the lid is still popped up after cooking, it's not safe to eat. But if it smells fresh, has no mold, and the jar is properly processed and sealed, it might be okay. When in doubt, throw it out!

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

SAFE

Maya followed a tested recipe and used a boiling water canner because fruits are acidic enough for that method. Using new lids, filling jars hot, and processing for the full time kills harmful bacteria. Testing the seals makes sure no air or bacteria got in. This makes the peaches safe to store and eat later.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

NOT SAFE

Using old or dented lids can prevent jars from sealing properly, allowing bacteria or molds to grow. Processing for less time can leave harmful microorganisms alive. Unsealed jars may spoil quickly and could cause food poisoning if eaten.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

IT DEPENDS

Asian pears are low-acid fruits and need added acid (like lemon juice) during canning to make the environment safe for boiling water canning. If lemon juice was forgotten, bacteria like Clostridium botulinum could survive and grow, making the pears unsafe if stored unrefrigerated. If stored cold (in the fridge), the risk is much lower, but it's best to follow tested recipes and add acid for room-temperature storage safety.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

SAFE

This approach is safe because peaches are a high-acid fruit that can be safely processed in a boiling water canner. Using sterilized jars, following the correct processing time, allowing proper headspace, cooling jars correctly, and storing in a cool, dark place prevents growth of harmful microorganisms and spoilage.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

NOT SAFE

This is not safe because many fruits need added acid (like lemon juice) to ensure safe acidity levels for boiling water canning. Processing too short, not adjusting for altitude, or overfilling jars can prevent destroying harmful bacteria or achieving a proper vacuum seal. This may cause spoilage or botulism risk. Always follow tested recipes, add acid if called for, process full time, and maintain headspace.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

IT DEPENDS

Safety depends on the acidity of the fruit and recommended process. Asian pears are borderline low-acid and may require adding lemon juice or other acid to safely process in a boiling water canner. If acid isn't added, pressure canning may be needed. Always follow research-based instructions for specific fruit types and recipes to ensure safety.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

SAFE

Following a research-tested recipe for canning fruits ensures safety by using the correct processing time, temperature, and headspace. Boiling water canning is safe for high-acid fruits when volume, acidity, and jar size are correct, and altitude adjustments are made. Using clean, heat-tempered jars and new lids also ensures a proper seal and prevents spoilage.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

NOT SAFE

Underripe fruit is less acidic and may not be safely processed with standard boiling water canning times. Raw packing without preheating and underprocessing can lead to spoilage or growth of dangerous microorganisms, including botulism. Always use ripe fruit and follow tested recipes and processing times precisely.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

IT DEPENDS

Processing times for canning fruits must be adjusted for altitude as boiling temperature decreases at higher elevations. Not adjusting for altitude can result in inadequate heat treatment, risking spoilage or unsafe food. You must increase processing time or boiling water temperature by following altitude adjustment guidance to ensure safety.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

SAFE

This salsa is safe because you followed a tested recipe that has enough acid to stop bad germs from growing. Using bottled lemon juice and cooking it in a boiling water canner makes sure the salsa stays safe to eat.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

NOT SAFE

The popped lid and bad smell are signs that the tomatoes went bad. This can happen if the jar wasn't sealed right or if bad germs grew inside. Never eat canned food if the lid pops up, it smells bad, or looks funny.

Source: PNW 300 Canning tomatoes and tomato products

IT DEPENDS

Salsa safety depends on having enough acid like vinegar or lemon juice. If there's not enough acid, harmful germs can grow. To know if it's safe, you need to follow a tested recipe or keep the salsa in the fridge or freezer instead.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

SAFE

When canning tomato salsa, it's important to use a recipe tested for safety that adds enough acid, like lemon juice, to stop bacteria from growing. Processing the jars for the right time in a boiling water canner kills harmful germs. Proper sealing and storage keeps your salsa safe to eat.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

NOT SAFE

Tomatoes from frost-killed or overripe fruit can lose acidity, making them unsafe to can without extra acid added. Without enough acid, bacteria like Clostridium botulinum can grow during storage and cause serious illness.

Source: PNW 300 Canning tomatoes and tomato products

IT DEPENDS

If a jar doesn't seal, the canned salsa can spoil or let bacteria grow. But if you keep it cold in the fridge and use it quickly, it can be safe. Don't store unsealed jars at room temperature because harmful germs could grow.

Source: PNW 300 Canning tomatoes and tomato products

SAFE

This salsa is safe because Jamie followed a tested recipe that ensures enough acidity by adding lemon juice to tomatoes. Using high-quality tomatoes and processing in a boiling water canner properly prevents harmful bacteria like botulism.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

NOT SAFE

This salsa is unsafe because reducing vinegar lowers acidity, which increases risk for botulism. Adding fresh garlic and herbs before canning also affects acidity and safety. Both changes can allow harmful bacteria to grow during boiling water canning.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

IT DEPENDS

Adding extra corn and beans before canning changes the acid balance and may lower the acidity, increasing botulism risk. These salsas must be canned according to tested recipes that account for such ingredients. If no tested recipe exists, it's safer to freeze instead.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

SAFE

This salsa is safe because it follows a research-tested recipe that ensures enough acidity by adding bottled lemon juice, uses the proper processing time in a boiling water canner, and uses high-quality, fresh tomatoes. Processing time and acidity are critical to prevent botulism in salsas, which contain low-acid ingredients mixed with tomatoes. Following exact recipes and methods that have been lab-tested guarantees safety.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

NOT SAFE

Not adding bottled lemon juice or vinegar can result in inadequate acidity, allowing Clostridium botulinum bacteria to grow, which can cause botulism-a serious foodborne illness. Also, under-processing (shorter than recommended time) does not safely eliminate bacteria. Salsa must have controlled acidity and proper processing time to be safe.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

IT DEPENDS

The safety depends on the exact acidity level of your salsa. Without a tested recipe specifying acid type and amount, you cannot be sure the acid level is sufficient to prevent botulism. The processing time is adequate if acidity is correct, but unknown acidity means the risk cannot be ruled out. Untested recipes should only be frozen or refrigerated, not canned.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

SAFE

Because green beans are low acid, they must be processed in a pressure canner to reach a high enough temperature that kills harmful bacteria. When canned this way and sealed tight, the food is safe to eat. Pressure canning protects us from dangerous germs like botulism that can grow in low acid foods if not heated enough.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

NOT SAFE

When the lid pops up, it means the jar did not seal properly and bad germs could have grown inside. These germs can make the food unsafe even if it looks or smells okay. It's best to throw the jar away to stay safe.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

IT DEPENDS

Low acid foods need to be kept hot or refrigerated after opening because bacteria can grow if left out too long. Even if the jar sealed initially, if it smells funny or shows mold, it is not safe. But if it smells fresh and has no mold, cooking it again can make it safe.

Source: PNW 450 Canning smoked fish at home

SAFE

Green beans are low-acid foods, so they must be canned in a pressure canner to reach high enough temperatures to kill harmful bacteria like Clostridium botulinum. Using tested recipes and following exact pressure and time ensures safety. Properly sealed jars stored in a cool, dark place remain safe to eat.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

NOT SAFE

Cooked meat is a low-acid food that can harbor botulism bacteria unless canned at high temperature in a pressure canner. Boiling water bath canners don't reach a high enough temperature, so contamination and toxin risk remain, even if jars appear sealed and food looks normal.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

LA-W02

IT DEPENDS

Garlic in oil is a low-acid food that can grow botulism bacteria if not stored properly. Keeping it refrigerated helps, but homemade garlic oils are safe for only about 3 weeks unless they're acidified. After that, the risk of botulism toxin increases, so safety depends on how long and how cold it's stored.

Source: PNW 450 Canning smoked fish at home

SAFE

Low-acid foods like green beans must be pressure canned to kill bacteria like Clostridium botulinum. Using a tested recipe with the correct pressure, time, and equipment ensures safety. Checking your canner's dial gauge each year ensures it works properly.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

NOT SAFE

Cooked potatoes are low-acid foods and need pressure canning to reach temperatures high enough to kill botulism spores. Using only boiling water canning is not safe and can allow harmful bacteria to grow, even if the jar looks fine.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

IT DEPENDS

Low acid foods need precise processing times to destroy dangerous bacteria. Shortening the time may result in unsafe food. Whether it's safe depends on how much time was cut, the type of food, and the canner's temperature. It's safer to follow tested times exactly.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

LA-T03

SAFE

Using a tested recipe with the correct processing time, headspace, and altitude adjustment ensures the destruction of Clostridium botulinum spores in low-acid foods. Correct equipment maintenance, like accurate pressure gauges, is critical for safety. Pressure canning reaches the necessary temperature (240°F) that boiling water canners cannot achieve.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

NOT SAFE

Spaghetti sauce with meat is a low-acid food and must be processed in a pressure canner, not a boiling water canner. Boiling water cannot reach the 240°F needed to kill botulism spores. Processing low-acid foods incorrectly risks deadly botulism poisoning, even if the food looks and smells normal.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

IT DEPENDS

Garlic in oil is a low-acid food and can support Clostridium botulinum growth without proper acidification. Commercial products are acidified to prevent bacterial growth. Safety depends precisely on following tested acidification procedures; if acidification is incomplete or inconsistent, the product is unsafe at room temperature. Otherwise, it must be refrigerated or frozen.

Source: PNW 450 Canning smoked fish at home

SAFE

When you use real vinegar with enough sourness and keep everything clean, the pickles stay safe to eat. The vinegar stops bad germs from growing. It's important to not use homemade vinegar and to use fresh vegetables and a clean jar.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

NOT SAFE

If the jar lid is popped up and the pickles smell bad or look moldy or cloudy, this means bad bacteria or germs have grown. It is unsafe to eat, and you should throw it away to not get sick.

Source: UC David Safely fermented fruit and vegetable

IT DEPENDS

Sometimes bubbling means the pickles are fermenting safely, making good acid to protect them. But if the jar wasn't clean, or the lid popped open a lot, or the smell is bad, it might be dangerous. Check if it smells nice and sour and has no mold. If it smells bad or looks fuzzy, it's not safe.

Source: UC David Safely fermented fruit and vegetable

SAFE

Using vinegar with 5% acidity is very important for safety because it prevents harmful bacteria from growing. Sticking closely to the recipe's vinegar amount ensures the pickles will be safe to eat. Keeping pickles refrigerated after sealing helps stop bacteria from growing.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

NOT SAFE

Lime used for pickling must be food-grade and not garden or lumberyard lime, which can be toxic. Also, not rinsing cucumbers after soaking in lime can leave harmful chemicals that are unsafe to eat.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

IT DEPENDS

Fermented pickles need to be kept under the brine and covered to prevent mold and insects. Some bubbles are normal from fermentation, but mold can be unsafe. Safety depends on whether the mold is just on the surface and if you remove it or if the fermentation was done correctly.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

SAFE

Using a tested recipe with vinegar that has 5% acidity ensures the pickles are acidic enough to prevent harmful bacteria. Refrigeration slows down spoilage. Consuming within 2 weeks means the pickles remain fresh and safe.

Source: NCHFP Pickled eggs

NOT SAFE

Homemade vinegar with unknown acidity may not be acidic enough to prevent harmful bacteria like Clostridium botulinum. Skipping boiling water processing risks unsafe contamination. Storing at room temperature increases the danger of bacteria growth.

Source: NCHFP Pickled eggs

IT DEPENDS

Fermentation safety depends on using the proper amount of salt to encourage good bacteria and keep bad bacteria out. Clean equipment and fresh vegetables are also needed. If these conditions aren't met, harmful bacteria might grow.

Source: UC David Safely fermented fruit and vegetable

PICKLING

Adults

PK-A01

SAFE

Following a tested recipe ensures the correct acidity and processing time to prevent bacterial growth and spoilage. Using the proper vinegar concentration and processing time adjusted for altitude guarantees safety. Proper headspace and clean jars prevent contamination and allow for adequate heat penetration during processing.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

NOT SAFE

Homemade vinegar can vary widely in acidity and may not reach the critical 5% acidity needed to safely inhibit bacterial growth. Without proper acid levels and heat processing, harmful bacteria, including Clostridium botulinum, can grow leading to poisoning. Processing ensures destruction of pathogens.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

IT DEPENDS

Quick pickles require boiling water processing to ensure safety, but processing time must be adjusted for altitude. At 4,000 feet, processing time is longer to compensate for lower boiling temperature. Without proper adjustment, safety is not guaranteed.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

SAFE

When jam jars are boiled for the proper time, sealed tightly, and look clear without mold or bubbles, they are safe to eat. The popping lid shows a good vacuum seal that keeps air and germs out. Always check the smell and look to make sure nothing is wrong before eating.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

NOT SAFE

If you see fuzzy mold or green spots on jelly, or the jelly smells bad or sour, it means it can be dangerous to eat. Also, if the lid is popped up, it shows no seal, and germs can spoil the jelly. Always throw away jelly with mold or off smells.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

IT DEPENDS

When jam is left out too long, it can grow germs, especially if the lid seal is broken. But if it looks clear, smells sweet and fresh, and there is no fuzzy mold, it might still be okay for a short time. Use your nose and eyes to decide, but when in doubt, don't eat it.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

SAFE

Emma used a proven recipe with enough sugar and acid, boiled the jam to kill harmful germs, sealed the jars tightly, and stored them properly. This keeps the jam safe to eat for a long time.

Source: SP 50-765 Low sugar fruit spreads

NOT SAFE

Liam didn't add enough acid or cook the jam long enough, so it might not be acidic enough to stop bad bacteria from growing. This can make the jam spoil or even cause food poisoning.

Source: SP 50-765 Low sugar fruit spreads

IT DEPENDS

Freezer jam is safe if kept frozen, since freezing stops bacteria. But if kept in the fridge for a week, it might spoil because it's not cooked like boiled jam. It's important to follow the recipe's storage instructions.

Source: SP 50-763 Uncooked freezer jams

SAFE

Freezer jams that use tested low-sugar pectin recipes and are kept frozen are safe. The freezing stops bacterial growth, and the tested recipe ensures the right acidity and pectin for safety and texture. Just follow the instructions on the pectin package and store the jam in the freezer until use.

Source: SP 50-763 Uncooked freezer jams

NOT SAFE

Skipping the boiling water bath means the jam isn't processed to kill bacteria and molds that can grow in home-canned food. Even acid jams need processing to be safe on the shelf. Without processing, your jam could spoil or cause food poisoning like botulism.

Source: SP 50-764 Making jam jellies fruit spreads

IT DEPENDS

Elderberry jelly safety depends on the variety of elderberry used because some have too low acidity for safe home canning with regular recipes. The native blue elderberry is safe with normal boiling water canning, but European and American elderberries need special high sugar recipes or freezing to be safe. Always identify your berry variety and follow the correct recipe.

Source: SP 50-536 Wild berries and fruits

SAFE

Using low-methoxyl pectin for low-sugar jams is safe because it's designed to set without high sugar levels. Processing in a boiling water canner for the recommended time ensures destruction of molds and pathogens. Refrigeration after opening prevents spoilage.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

NOT SAFE

Mold on jams and jellies can contaminate the entire product below the surface, and molds may produce dangerous mycotoxins. It is unsafe to simply remove mold and consume the rest. The entire jar should be discarded to prevent illness.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

IT DEPENDS

Pepper jellies with low-acid vegetables depend on added acid (like vinegar or lemon juice) for safety. Without sufficient acidification, processing alone cannot guarantee safe acidity (pH below 4.6), risking botulism. Safety depends on following a tested recipe that includes acid.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

SAFE

When frozen food is kept at the right cold temperature and stays frozen, it stops germs from growing. The blueberries stay safe to eat if they never thaw before you take them out. Keeping the freezer cold and not opening it too much helps keep the food good and safe.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

NOT SAFE

When canned food freezes and the can lid bulges or seams break, it means germs might have grown inside and made the food bad. So it's best to throw it away to keep from getting sick because bulging cans mean danger.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home

IT DEPENDS

If a jar lid pops up after freezing, the seal might be broken, which lets air in and germs can grow. But if the jam still smells sweet, looks good, and isn't moldy, it can be eaten. If it smells bad or has mold, it's not safe and should be thrown away.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home

SAFE

Cooling leftover foods quickly before freezing helps stop bacteria from growing. Keeping the freezer at 0°F or below keeps food safe and preserves quality for months. Food kept at this temperature is safe to eat even after long storage.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

NOT SAFE

If a can is bulging or the lid is broken, bacteria might have grown inside even if it was frozen. Eating food from damaged cans can cause food poisoning, so it should be thrown away.

Source: SP 50-695 Safety of canned food that freezes

IT DEPENDS

Thawing meat in the fridge is safe if you cook or freeze it within a couple of days. After 3 days, the meat might start to spoil and could make you sick. Always check the meat for smell or color changes before cooking.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home

SAFE

Quick cooling stops bacteria from growing before freezing. Freezing at 0°F keeps the soup safe for months by halting bacteria growth. Leaving headspace lets the soup expand when frozen, preventing container breakage. Always use freezer-safe containers.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home

NOT SAFE

Freezing raw meat without packaging can allow freezer burns and contamination. Thawing meat on the counter lets harmful bacteria grow rapidly at room temperature. Meat must be thawed safely in the fridge or cold water, never at room temperature.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home

IT DEPENDS

Leftover cooked rice must be cooled quickly and frozen soon to stay safe because it can grow bacteria that cause food poisoning. Thawing frozen veggies in the fridge is safe, as is cooking them straight from frozen. The safety depends on how long the rice stayed in the danger zone before freezing and vegetable acidity.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

SAFE

Freezing cooked soup right after rapid cooling prevents harmful bacterial growth. Using airtight containers and a freezer at 0°F (-18°C) maintains safety and quality. Labeling with dates helps with proper food rotation and timely use to maintain quality.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home

NOT SAFE

When canned foods freeze and cans bulge or seams break, the risk of spoilage increases. Using thawed canned foods with bulging or damaged cans without further heat treatment can expose you to dangerous bacteria like Clostridium botulinum. Such foods should be discarded or boiled 10 minutes before using if still safe physically.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home

IT DEPENDS

Safety depends on how long the beans were above 40°F. If they stayed above 40°F for less than 2 hours and still contain ice crystals, refreezing is generally safe though quality may suffer. Longer warm exposure can allow bacteria to grow, making refreezing unsafe. Cook immediately if unsure, or discard if suspect.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

SAFE

Drying apples until they are leathery means most water is gone, so bad germs can't grow. Keeping them in a clean, airtight place stops new germs from getting on them. This way, your dried apples stay safe to eat!

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables

NOT SAFE

A bad smell and sticky, slimy fish means germs might be growing. If fish smells funny or looks slimy, it can make you sick. It's best to throw it away instead of eating it.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

IT DEPENDS

Jerky is safe when it is dried well and stored in a cool, dry place. But if it smells bad or looks moldy, it can make you sick. Watch for bad smells or fuzzy spots-that's when it's not safe.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

SAFE

If fruit is properly dried so it has very little moisture left, and stored in a cool, dark place that prevents moisture and light, it stays safe to eat. This stops mold and bacteria from growing.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables

NOT SAFE

Small metal smokers often can't reach high enough temperatures to kill harmful bacteria. If fish isn't cooked to 160°F after smoking, it might still have dangerous germs that can make you sick.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

IT DEPENDS

Jerky made safely requires the meat to be heated to 160°F before or right after drying to kill germs. If the meat wasn't heated properly, it might still contain harmful bacteria. So, safety depends on whether the meat reached that temperature.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

SAFE

Jerky is only safe if the meat reaches 160°F to destroy harmful bacteria such as Salmonella and E. coli. Using a dehydrator that keeps a steady temperature of 145°F-155°F and verifying the final internal temperature ensures safety. This method prevents foodborne illness and allows jerky to be shelf-stable for weeks.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

NOT SAFE

Smoking fish without controlling temperature or time can allow dangerous bacteria or parasites to survive. Unlike proper cooking, cold or uncontrolled smoking does not reliably kill pathogens, risking foodborne illness such as from Clostridium botulinum or parasites like Trichinella.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

IT DEPENDS

Drying acidic fruits like tomatoes is usually safer because harmful bacteria grow less in acid. However, safety depends on how long you dry them, the drying temperature, and finishing steps. Tomatoes need to be dried until moisture is low enough to prevent spoilage, and if not dried properly, can still grow mold or bacteria.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables

SAFE

Drying jerky safely requires drying meat at a temperature of at least 145°F to kill pathogens. Using a dehydrator with a thermostatically controlled temperature dial and confirming with an external thermometer helps ensure the safety of the dried product.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

NOT SAFE

Smoking fish without monitoring internal temperature and time can allow harmful bacteria to survive, particularly Clostridium botulinum. Uncontrolled smoking is risky and can result in foodborne illness.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

IT DEPENDS

The safety of drying tomatoes depends on ensuring the drying temperature is high enough (usually above 130°F) for a sufficient time to reduce moisture safely. Altitude affects drying times and temperatures needed. Without knowing these details or controlling temperature, safety cannot be assured.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables